

Option 11: Medicine in Britain, c1250–present and The British sector of the Western Front, 1914–18: injuries, treatment and the trenches

Medicine in Britain, c1250–present

The process of change

- In studying the content defined below in strands 1 and 2, students should understand how key features in the development of medicine were linked with the key features of society in Britain in the periods studied.
- They should develop an understanding of the nature and process of change. This will involve understanding patterns of change, trends and turning points, and the influence of factors inhibiting or encouraging change within periods and across the theme. The key factors are:
 - individuals and institutions (Church and government)
 - science and technology
 - attitudes in society.
- They should also understand how factors worked together to bring about particular developments at particular times.
- The selected case studies in strand 3 of each period exemplify, in context, the elements defined in strands 1 and 2. They provide opportunities to explore the operation of the key factors and to make detailed comparisons over time.

c1250–c1500: Medicine in medieval England

1 Ideas about the cause of disease and illness	• Supernatural and religious explanations of the cause of disease. • Rational explanations: the Theory of the Four Humours and the miasma theory; the continuing influence in England of Galen.
2 Approaches to prevention and treatment	• Approaches to prevention and treatment, and their connection with ideas about disease and illness: religious actions, bloodletting and purging, purifying the air. • Medical training and traditional approaches to treatment and care for the sick: the role of the physician, apothecary and barber surgeon; the role of hospitals, care within the community and at home, including the use of herbal remedies.
3 Case study	• Dealing with the Black Death, 1348–49; approaches to treatment and attempts to prevent its spread.

c1500–c1700: The Medical Renaissance in England

1 Ideas about the cause of disease and illness	• Continuity and change in explanations of the cause of disease and illness. A scientific approach, including the work of Thomas Sydenham in improving diagnosis. The influence of the printing press and the work of the Royal Society on the transmission of ideas.
2 Approaches to prevention and treatment	• Continuity and change in approaches to prevention, treatment and care in the community and in hospitals. • Improvements in medical training and the influence in England of the work of Vesalius.
3 Case studies	• Key individual: William Harvey and the discovery of the circulation of the blood. • Dealing with the Great Plague in London (1665): approaches to treatment and attempts to prevent its spread.

c1700–c1900: Medicine in eighteenth- and nineteenth-century Britain

1 Ideas about the cause of disease and illness	• Continuity and change in explanations of the cause of disease and illness. The influence in Britain of Pasteur's Germ Theory and Koch's work on microbes.
2 Approaches to prevention and treatment	• The extent of change in care and treatment: improvements in hospital care and the influence of Nightingale on nursing and hospitals in Britain. The impact of anaesthetics and antiseptics on surgery. • New approaches to prevention: the development and use of vaccinations and the Public Health Act (1875).
3 Case studies	• Key individual: Jenner and the development of vaccination. • Fighting Cholera in London (1854); attempts to prevent its spread; the significance of Snow and the Broad Street pump.

c1900–present: Medicine in modern Britain

1 Ideas about the cause of disease and illness	• Advances in understanding the causes of illness and disease: the influence of genetic and lifestyle factors on health. • Improvements in diagnosis: the impact of the availability of blood tests, scans and monitors.
2 Approaches to prevention and treatment	• The extent of change in care and treatment. The impact of the NHS and science and technology: improved access to care; advances in medicines, including magic bullets and antibiotics; high-tech medical and surgical treatment in hospitals. • New approaches to prevention: mass vaccinations and government lifestyle campaigns.
3 Case studies	• Key individuals: Fleming, Florey and Chain's development of penicillin. • The fight against lung cancer in the twenty-first century: the use of science and technology in diagnosis and treatment; government action.

The British sector of the Western Front, 1914–18: injuries, treatment and the trenches

The historic environment

1 The British sector of the Western Front, 1914–18: injuries, treatment and the trenches	• The context of the British sector of Western Front and the theatre of war in Flanders and northern France: the Ypres salient, the Somme, Arras and Cambrai. The trench system - its organisation, including frontline and support trenches. Significance for medical treatment of the nature of the terrain and problems of the transport and communications infrastructure. • Conditions requiring medical treatment on the Western Front, including the problems of ill health arising from the trench environment. The nature of wounds from rifles and explosives. The problem of shrapnel, wound infection and increased numbers of head injuries. The effects of gas attacks. • Medical treatment on the Western Front. The work of the RAMC and nurses. Transport in the chain of evacuation: stretcher bearers, horse and motor ambulances. Stages of treatment in the chain of evacuation: aid post and field ambulance, dressing station, casualty clearing station, base hospital. The underground hospital at Arras. • The significance of the Western Front for experiments in surgery and medicine: new techniques in the treatment of wounds and infection, the Thomas splint, the use of mobile x-ray units, the creation of a blood bank for the Battle of Cambrai. • The historical context of medicine in the early twentieth century: the understanding of infection and moves towards aseptic surgery; the development of x-rays; blood transfusions and developments in the storage of blood.
2 Knowledge, selection and use of sources for historical enquiries	• Knowledge of national sources relevant to the period and issue, e.g. army records, national newspapers, government reports, medical articles. • Knowledge of local sources relevant to the period and issue, e.g. personal accounts, photographs, hospital records, army statistics. • Recognition of the strengths and weaknesses of different types of source for specific enquiries. • Framing of questions relevant to the pursuit of a specific enquiry. • Selection of appropriate sources for specific investigations.